the terrifying and destructive aspects of existence. Associated with this cult was that of the eight mother goddesses and their expressions in families (*kula* – hence the term *Kaula* for forms of *Shiva* worship allied to the *Trika*) of female spirits called *Yoginis*. They may be invoked and pacified, in the impure cremation ground on the margins of society, with offerings of impure and hence potent substances such as blood, flesh, wine and sexual fluids. The cult adopted the horrific, all-devouring *Kalasamkarshini* form of the goddess *Kali* as the unifying form of the original three.

From 900 CE the *Trika* was in competition with the dualistic system of ritual and theology known as ***Shaiva Siddhanta***, according to which really individual selves inhabit a physical world. Articulated in the sophisticated ***Pratyabhijna*** philosophy whose chief proponents are ***Utpaladeva*** and ***Abhinavagupta***, the *Trika* was able to defeat the challenges posed by dualism, *Vedantic* illusionism and Buddhism. Its explicitly sexual rituals underwent a process of domestication and internalisation. This trend appears in the thought of ***Abhinavagupta*** where orgasm is understood as manifesting the expansion of blissful self-awareness, the same as the universal consciousness projecting all phenomena, annihilating one's self-centredness. Likewise, impure substances, which had been understood as sources of magical powers are held to induce ecstasy, a sense of freedom arising from violation of the taboo. *Trika* votaries understand bondage to worldly existence as the self-limitation that sees the orthodox values of purity and impurity as objective realities. Enlightenment is the realisation that anxious concern about ***caste*** and related values such as one's *Vedic* learning, family's status, prescribed conduct, conventional virtues and prosperity are aspects of an inauthentic identity.

Further reading: Sanderson 1990; White 2003